

6-torsion in class groups of quadratic fields

Frank Thorne

j/w Peter Koymans, Robert Lemke Oliver, and Efthymios Sofos

University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC, USA

AMS Sectional Meeting, Kennesaw State University

`thornef.github.io/6-torsion-kennesaw.pdf`



Question: given $m > 1$, what can we say about

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m] := \{[\mathfrak{a}] \in \mathrm{Cl}(D) : [\mathfrak{a}]^m = [(1)]\} ?$$

2-torsion: Gauss's genus theory

Theorem (Gauss's genus theory ($D < 0$ case))

If $D < 0$, we have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[2] \simeq (\mathbb{Z}/2)^{\omega(D)-1},$$

where $\omega(D)$ counts the **unique prime divisors** of D .

2-torsion: Gauss's genus theory

Theorem (Gauss's genus theory ($D < 0$ case))

If $D < 0$, we have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[2] \simeq (\mathbb{Z}/2)^{\omega(D)-1},$$

where $\omega(D)$ counts the **unique prime divisors** of D .

Theorem (Gauss's genus theory ($D > 0$ case))

If $D > 0$, we have

$$\mathrm{Cl}^+(D)[2] \simeq (\mathbb{Z}/2)^{\omega(D)-1},$$

and

$$\mathrm{Cl}^+(D)[2] \simeq \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2] \times (\mathbb{Z}/2)$$

if D has any prime divisor $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$.

Conjectures on p -torsion

Conjecture (Cohen-Lenstra)

Let p be an odd prime. Then, on average, $\text{Cl}(D)[p]$ is “a random abelian p -group”.

Conjectures on p -torsion

Conjecture (Cohen-Lenstra)

Let p be an odd prime. Then, on average, $\text{Cl}(D)[p]$ is “a random abelian p -group”.

(There is much to be said about this!)

Conjectures on p -torsion

Conjecture (Cohen-Lenstra)

Let p be an odd prime. Then, on average, $\text{Cl}(D)[p]$ is “a random abelian p -group”.

(There is much to be said about this!)

Conjecture (Brumer-Silverman)

For any number field K and prime p , we have

$$\#\text{Cl}(D)[p] \ll |\text{Disc}(D)|^\epsilon.$$

Asymptotic results

Problem: Given $m \geq 2$, prove asymptotic formulas for

$$\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m].$$

Asymptotic results

Problem: Given $m \geq 2$, prove asymptotic formulas for

$$\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m].$$

Known cases:

Asymptotic results

Problem: Given $m \geq 2$, prove asymptotic formulas for

$$\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m].$$

Known cases:

- ▶ $m = 2$: “Classical” and “well known”

Asymptotic results

Problem: Given $m \geq 2$, prove asymptotic formulas for

$$\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m].$$

Known cases:

- ▶ $m = 2$: “Classical” and “well known”
- ▶ $m = 3$: Davenport-Heilbronn (1971)

Asymptotic results

Problem: Given $m \geq 2$, prove asymptotic formulas for

$$\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m].$$

Known cases:

- ▶ $m = 2$: “Classical” and “well known”
- ▶ $m = 3$: Davenport-Heilbronn (1971)
- ▶ $m = 4$: Fouvry-Klüners (2007)

Asymptotic results

Problem: Given $m \geq 2$, prove asymptotic formulas for

$$\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m].$$

Known cases:

- ▶ $m = 2$: “Classical” and “well known”
- ▶ $m = 3$: Davenport-Heilbronn (1971)
- ▶ $m = 4$: Fouvry-Klüners (2007)
- ▶ $m = 2^k$: Smith (2022)

Asymptotic results

Problem: Given $m \geq 2$, prove asymptotic formulas for

$$\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\mathrm{Cl}(D)[m].$$

Known cases:

- ▶ $m = 2$: “Classical” and “well known”
- ▶ $m = 3$: Davenport-Heilbronn (1971)
- ▶ $m = 4$: Fouvry-Klüners (2007)
- ▶ $m = 2^k$: Smith (2022)
- ▶ $m = 6$: **New!** KLOST (2025)

Main Results

Theorem (Koymans, Lemke Oliver, Sofos, T.)

We have

$$\sum_{-X < D < 0} \# \text{Cl}(D)[6] = \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{1}{p+1}\right) \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right) X \log(X) + O(X(\log \log X)^7)$$

$$\sum_{0 < D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[6] = \frac{1}{\pi^2} \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{1}{p+1}\right) \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right) X \log(X) + o(X \log(X)).$$

Main Results

Theorem (Koymans, Lemke Oliver, Sofos, T.)

We have

$$\sum_{-X < D < 0} \# \text{Cl}(D)[6] = \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{1}{p+1}\right) \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right) X \log(X) + O(X(\log \log X)^7)$$

$$\sum_{0 < D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[6] = \frac{1}{\pi^2} \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{1}{p+1}\right) \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right) X \log(X) + o(X \log(X)).$$

Improves upon (and uses!):

Theorem (Chan, Koymans, Pagano, Sofos)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < \pm D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[6] \ll X \log(X).$$

Theorem

We have

$$N_{12}(X, D_6) = CX^{1/6}(\log X)^2 + O(X^{1/6}(\log X)^{1+\epsilon}).$$

The Basic Idea

We have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \simeq \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \times \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2]$$

The Basic Idea

We have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \simeq \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \times \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2]$$

Count $\mathrm{Cl}(D)[3]$ and $\mathrm{Cl}(D)[2]$ “at the same time”.

Asymptotics for 2-class numbers:

Theorem

We have

$$\sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[2] \sim \frac{3}{2\pi^2} X \log X \cdot \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{1}{p+1}\right) \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right).$$

Asymptotics for 2-class numbers:

Theorem

We have

$$\sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[2] \sim \frac{3}{2\pi^2} X \log X \cdot \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{1}{p+1}\right) \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right).$$

This is “easy” and “well known”.

Asymptotics for 2-class numbers (2):

Since

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[2] \simeq (\mathbb{Z}/2)^{\omega(D)-1},$$

we have “morally”

$$\sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2] \text{ “} = \text{” } \frac{1}{2} \sum_{\substack{0 < n < X \\ \text{squarefree}}} \tau(n),$$

where $\tau(n)$ counts the positive divisors of n .

Asymptotics for 2-class numbers (3):

We have

$$\begin{aligned}\sum_{n>0 \text{ squarefree}} \tau(n) n^{-s} &= \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{2}{p^s}\right) \\ &= \zeta(s)^2 \cdot \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{2}{p^s}\right)^{-1} \left(1 - \frac{1}{p^s}\right)^{-2},\end{aligned}$$

and

$$\sum_{\substack{0 < n < X \\ \text{squarefree}}} \tau(n) = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{2-i\infty}^{2+i\infty} \zeta(s)^2 \cdot \prod_p \left(1 + \frac{2}{p^s}\right)^{-1} \left(1 - \frac{1}{p^s}\right)^{-2} X^s \frac{ds}{s}.$$

Asymptotics for 3-class numbers (1):

Theorem (Davenport-Heilbronn, 1971)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] \sim \frac{3+3}{\pi^2} X,$$

and

$$\sum_{0 < D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] \sim \frac{3+1}{\pi^2} X.$$

How to prove Davenport-Heilbronn

By class field theory, if D is a fundamental discriminant, then *cubic fields of discriminant D* are in bijection with *subgroups of $\text{Cl}(D)$ of index 3*.

Let V be the space of binary cubic forms:

$$V := \{x(u, v) = au^3 + bu^2v + cuv^2 + dv^3\}.$$

GL_2 acts on V by

$$(gx)(u, v) = x((u, v)g).$$

We have

$$\text{Disc}(x) = b^2c^2 - 4ac^3 - 4b^3d - 27a^2d^2 + 18abcd,$$

for which we have

- ▶ $\text{Disc}(gx) = (\det g)^6 \text{Disc}(x)$;
- ▶ $\text{Disc}(x) = 0$ if and only if $x(u, v)$ has a repeated root.

Definition: A cubic ring is a ring which is free of rank 3 as a $\mathbb{Z}$ -module. *Irreducible, nondegenerate* cubic rings are orders in cubic fields.

Theorem: (Delone-Faddeev, 1964) There is a 'nice' bijection between:

- ▶ Cubic rings up to isomorphism; and,
- ▶ $\text{GL}_2(\mathbb{Z})$ -equivalence classes of *integral* binary cubic forms.

Theorem: (Davenport-Heilbronn) A cubic ring R is maximal iff its cubic form f satisfies certain congruence conditions $(\text{mod } p^2)$, for every prime p .

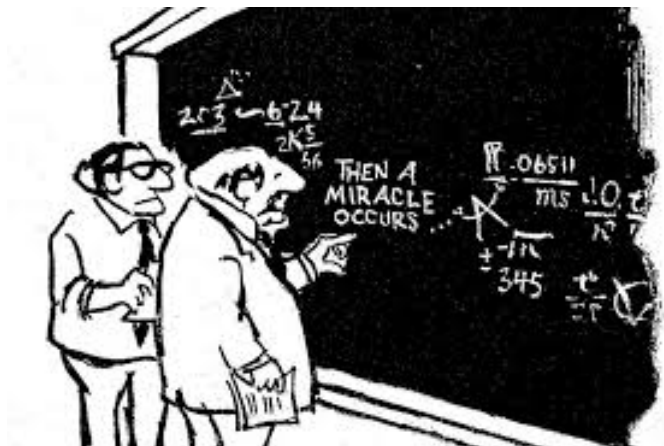
To count cubic fields, count their *maximal orders*. Therefore, we may start with cubic forms and sieve for:

- ▶ Nondegeneracy ($\text{Disc}(x) \neq 0$);
- ▶ Irreducibility;
- ▶ Maximality (for each prime p).

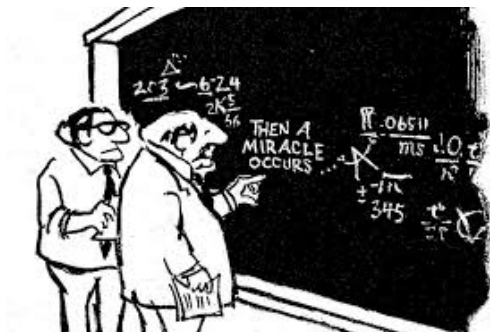
Techniques:

- ▶ Geometry of numbers, with **Bhargava's averaging method**;
- ▶ **Shintani zeta functions**.

Alternative Proof of Davenport-Heilbronn



Alternative Proof of Davenport-Heilbronn (2)



Count **lattice points** in a **four-dimensional vector space** satisfying **certain congruence conditions**.

A Stronger Davenport-Heilbronn Theorem

Theorem (BBDHPSTTT*)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < \pm D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] = \frac{3 + 3 + 3 + 1}{\pi^2} X + cX^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

A Stronger Davenport-Heilbronn Theorem

Theorem (BBDHPSTTT*)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < \pm D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] = \frac{3 + 3 + 3 + 1}{\pi^2} X + cX^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

*: Belabas, Bhargava, Davenport, Heilbronn, Pomerance, Shankar, Taniguchi, T., Tsimerman

A Stronger Davenport-Heilbronn Theorem

Theorem (BBDHPSTTT*)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < \pm D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] = \frac{3 + 3 + 3 + 1}{\pi^2} X + cX^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

*: Belabas, Bhargava, Davenport, Heilbronn, Pomerance, Shankar, Taniguchi, T., Tsimerman

Variations:

A Stronger Davenport-Heilbronn Theorem

Theorem (BBDHPSTTT*)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < \pm D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] = \frac{3 + 3 + 3 + 1}{\pi^2} X + cX^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

*: Belabas, Bhargava, Davenport, Heilbronn, Pomerance, Shankar, Taniguchi, T., Tsimerman

Variations:

- ▶ Counting **all cubic fields** (including non-fundamental discriminants);

A Stronger Davenport-Heilbronn Theorem

Theorem (BBDHPSTTT*)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < \pm D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] = \frac{3 + 3 + 3 + 1}{\pi^2} X + cX^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

*: Belabas, Bhargava, Davenport, Heilbronn, Pomerance, Shankar, Taniguchi, T., Tsimerman

Variations:

- ▶ Counting **all cubic fields** (including non-fundamental discriminants);
- ▶ Allowing for **local specifications**;

A Stronger Davenport-Heilbronn Theorem

Theorem (BBDHPSTTT*)

We have

$$\sum_{0 < \pm D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] = \frac{3 + 3 + 3 + 1}{\pi^2} X + cX^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

*: Belabas, Bhargava, Davenport, Heilbronn, Pomerance, Shankar, Taniguchi, T., Tsimerman

Variations:

- ▶ Counting **all cubic fields** (including non-fundamental discriminants);
- ▶ Allowing for **local specifications**;
- ▶ A 'level of distribution' statement (**important later!!**)

How to count 6-torsion

We have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \simeq \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \times \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2],$$

How to count 6-torsion

We have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \simeq \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \times \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2],$$

so

$$\sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \approx \frac{1}{2} \sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \cdot \tau(D).$$

How to count 6-torsion

We have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \simeq \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \times \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2],$$

so

$$\sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \approx \frac{1}{2} \sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \cdot \tau(D).$$

Question: How can we count that???

How to count 6-torsion

We have

$$\mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \simeq \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \times \mathrm{Cl}(D)[2],$$

so

$$\sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \mathrm{Cl}(D)[6] \approx \frac{1}{2} \sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \mathrm{Cl}(D)[3] \cdot \tau(D).$$

Question: How can we count that???

Answer: Naively.

6-torsion: first steps

We have

$$\frac{1}{2} \sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] \cdot \tau(D) = \sum_{0 < d < \sqrt{X}} \mu^2(d) \sum_{\substack{d^2 < \text{sfk}(-D) < X \\ d|D}} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3].$$

6-torsion: first steps

We have

$$\frac{1}{2} \sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] \cdot \tau(D) = \sum_{0 < d < \sqrt{X}} \mu^2(d) \sum_{\substack{d^2 < \text{sfk}(-D) < X \\ d|D}} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3].$$

Theorem (Davenport-Heilbronn with divisibility)

We have

$$\sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\# \text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) = \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X + c'(D) X^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

6-torsion: first steps

We have

$$\frac{1}{2} \sum_{0 < -D < X} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3] \cdot \tau(D) = \sum_{0 < d < \sqrt{X}} \mu^2(d) \sum_{\substack{d^2 < \text{sfk}(-D) < X \\ d|D}} \# \text{Cl}(D)[3].$$

Theorem (Davenport-Heilbronn with divisibility)

We have

$$\sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\# \text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) = \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X + c'(D) X^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}).$$

So, we're done, right.....?

Sage Wisdom from Jean-Pierre Serre

“Another theorem says that $|Af|$ is smaller than $C|f|$, where C is a constant. A beautiful word! What is meant is real number, strictly positive, and you call it a constant because it doesn't depend – so it's a real number not depending on some of the data. Now, very often the theorem is taken with 'Let f be fixed.' So that, a priori, in normal good mathematics the constant would depend on f . But they do not say. And the constant may depend, certainly on A , but on many other things.

Sage Wisdom from Jean-Pierre Serre

“Another theorem says that $|Af|$ is smaller than $C|f|$, where C is a constant. A beautiful word! What is meant is real number, strictly positive, and you call it a constant because it doesn't depend – so it's a real number not depending on some of the data. Now, very often the theorem is taken with 'Let f be fixed.' So that, a priori, in normal good mathematics the constant would depend on f . But they do not say. And the constant may depend, certainly on A , but on many other things.

(J.-P. Serre, *How to Write Mathematics Badly*)

Sage Wisdom from Jean-Pierre Serre

“Another theorem says that $|Af|$ is smaller than $C|f|$, where C is a constant. A beautiful word! What is meant is real number, strictly positive, and you call it a constant because it doesn't depend – so it's a real number not depending on some of the data. Now, very often the theorem is taken with ‘Let f be fixed.’ So that, a priori, in normal good mathematics the constant would depend on f . But they do not say. And the constant may depend, certainly on A , but on many other things.

(J.-P. Serre, *How to Write Mathematics Badly*)

Theorem (Davenport-Heilbronn with divisibility)

We have

$$\sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#Cl(D)[3] - 1) = \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X + c'(D)X^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}),$$

where the implied “constant” depends on d .

Sage Wisdom from Jean-Pierre Serre

“Another theorem says that $|Af|$ is smaller than $C|f|$, where C is a constant. A beautiful word! What is meant is real number, strictly positive, and you call it a constant because it doesn't depend – so it's a real number not depending on some of the data. Now, very often the theorem is taken with 'Let f be fixed.' So that, a priori, in normal good mathematics the constant would depend on f . But they do not say. And the constant may depend, certainly on A , but on many other things.

(J.-P. Serre, *How to Write Mathematics Badly*)

Theorem (Davenport-Heilbronn with divisibility)

We have

$$\sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#Cl(D)[3] - 1) = \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X + c'(D)X^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}),$$

where the implied “constant” depends on d .

How?

Sage Wisdom from Jean-Pierre Serre

“Another theorem says that $|Af|$ is smaller than $C|f|$, where C is a constant. A beautiful word! What is meant is real number, strictly positive, and you call it a constant because it doesn't depend – so it's a real number not depending on some of the data. Now, very often the theorem is taken with 'Let f be fixed.' So that, a priori, in normal good mathematics the constant would depend on f . But they do not say. And the constant may depend, certainly on A , but on many other things.

(J.-P. Serre, *How to Write Mathematics Badly*)

Theorem (Davenport-Heilbronn with divisibility)

We have

$$\sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#\text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) = \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X + c'(D)X^{5/6} + O(X^{2/3+\epsilon}),$$

where the implied “constant” depends on d .

How? If you're not careful, badly.

Davenport-Heilbronn theorem, LOD version

Theorem

We have

$$\sum_{d < X^{1/2}(\log X)^{-5}} \left| \sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#\text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) - \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X \right| = o(X).$$

Davenport-Heilbronn theorem, LOD version

Theorem

We have

$$\sum_{d < X^{1/2}(\log X)^{-5}} \left| \sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#\text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) - \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X \right| = o(X).$$

Got $d \ll X^{1/2-\epsilon}$ in [Bhargava-Taniguchi-T.](#) To improve:

Davenport-Heilbronn theorem, LOD version

Theorem

We have

$$\sum_{d < X^{1/2}(\log X)^{-5}} \left| \sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#\text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) - \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X \right| = o(X).$$

Got $d \ll X^{1/2-\epsilon}$ in [Bhargava-Taniguchi-T.](#) To improve:

- Squeeze more out of existing proofs.

Davenport-Heilbronn theorem, LOD version

Theorem

We have

$$\sum_{d < X^{1/2}(\log X)^{-5}} \left| \sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#\text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) - \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X \right| = o(X).$$

Got $d \ll X^{1/2-\epsilon}$ in [Bhargava-Taniguchi-T.](#) To improve:

- ▶ Squeeze more out of existing proofs.
- ▶ Use $\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\text{Cl}(D)[3] \tau(D) \ll X \log X$ in the guts of the proof.

Davenport-Heilbronn theorem, LOD version

Theorem

We have

$$\sum_{d < X^{1/2}(\log X)^{-5}} \left| \sum_{\substack{0 < -D < X \\ d|D}} (\#\text{Cl}(D)[3] - 1) - \frac{3}{\pi^2} \prod_{p|D} \frac{p}{p^2 - 1} \cdot X \right| = o(X).$$

Got $d \ll X^{1/2-\epsilon}$ in [Bhargava-Taniguchi-T.](#) To improve:

- ▶ Squeeze more out of existing proofs.
- ▶ Use $\sum_{\pm D < X} \#\text{Cl}(D)[3] \tau(D) \ll X \log X$ in the guts of the proof.

Also, handle the range $X^{1/2}(\log X)^{-5} \leq d \leq X^{1/2}$ by different methods.

Theorem (Mori 2010)

Let $\Phi_p : V(\mathbb{Z}/p\mathbb{Z}) \rightarrow \{0, 1\}$ be the *characteristic function of singular binary cubic forms*. Then, we have

$$\widehat{\Phi_p}(v) = \begin{cases} p^{-1} + p^{-2} - p^{-3} & (v = 0), \\ p^{-2} - p^{-3} & (v \text{ has splitting type } (1^3) \text{ or } (1^2 1)), \\ -p^{-3} & (\text{otherwise}). \end{cases}$$